

who fought one another in Italy in a series of wars from the 1490s to the 1550s. Rome was laid waste by an imperial army in 1527. Observing these conflicts at close hand inspired

Florentine Niccolò Machiavelli to write his cynical political handbook *The Prince* in 1513 (published in 1532), advising the wise ruler to use any methods, however immoral, to stay in power. Whether or not this was good advice, it certainly described the normal practice of Renaissance political leaders. Machiavelli's model for *The Prince* was the ruthless Cesare Borgia (1476–1507), the illegitimate son of Pope Alexander VI, who was suspected of many murders, including that of his elder brother.



Niccolò Machiavelli

Author of *The Prince*, Machiavelli based his pragmatic political philosophy upon his experiences as a diplomat in the service of Florence.

15th century. Much of the thrust of Renaissance humanism, especially in the works of Erasmus, consisted of an attack on the ignorance and corruption of the clergy, including successive

popes, and calls for a return to a purer form of faith. On the other hand, Renaissance artists, as purveyors of luxury goods sometimes with pagan connotations, found their works under attack from religious reformers.

Religious revival

Between 1494 and 1498, a radical monk, Girolamo Savonarola, won control of Florence and led an orgy of book-burning and destruction of works of art in his campaign against wealth and corruption. One of the main provocations for the Reformation that challenged papal authority from 1517 was outrage at the money being spent on commissioning men such as Raphael and Michelangelo to beautify Rome. The atmosphere



Renaissance clock

The introduction of spring-powered timepieces at the start of the 16th century allowed smaller portable clocks such as this to be made for domestic use.

Challenge to the Church

Religious disputes grew out of a discontent with the state of the Church that was simmering throughout the

“It is much safer for a prince to be **feared than loved** if he is to fail in one of the two.”

NICCOLO MACHIAVELLI, FROM “THE PRINCE,” 1532

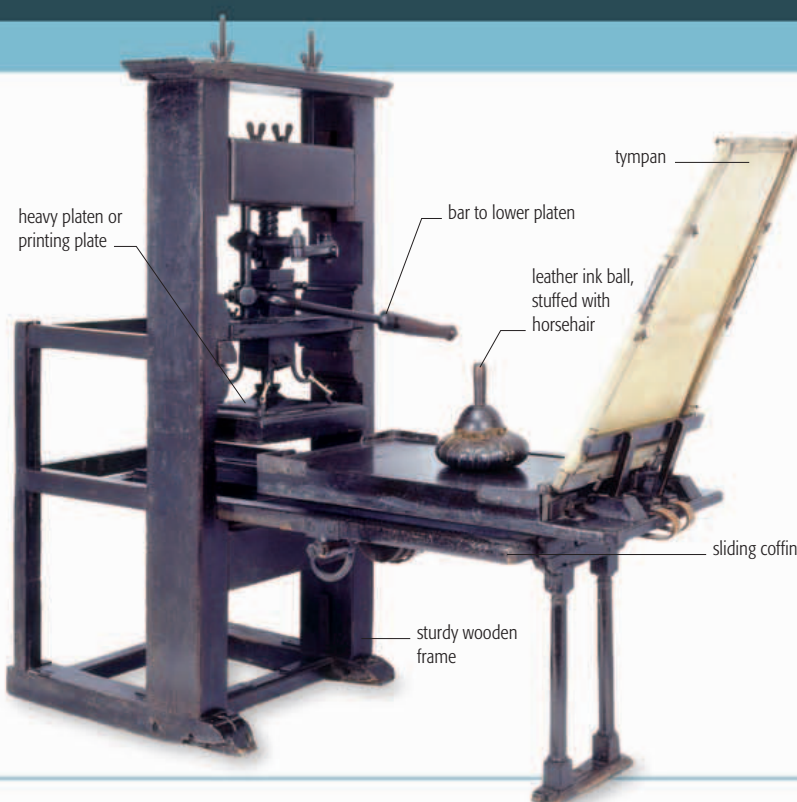
INVENTION

THE PRINTING PRESS

The first effective press for printing books using movable metal type and oil-based ink emerged in 15th century Europe. Its invention is attributed to Johannes Gutenberg, a German artisan and entrepreneur. The Bible that he published in 1455 was the first book printed in this way. The new technique spread, with presses established in Paris in 1470 and London in 1476. The most prestigious early printer, Aldus Manutius, set up the Aldine Press in Venice in 1494. By 1500 some 35,000 different books were in print. Much cheaper than hand-written works, printed books revolutionized the diffusion of knowledge.

“A spring of truth shall flow from it...”

GUTENBERG, 15TH CENTURY



Mercator map

Representing the latest knowledge of geography, this map was created by Flemish cartographer Gerardus Mercator in 1587. Mercator's projection, his famous method for representing the globe on a flat surface, was still in widespread use four centuries later.

of religious revival in the Reformation and the Counter-Reformation (see pp.258–59) was broadly hostile to the spirit of free inquiry and invention that animated the Renaissance. In the second half of the 16th century, both zealous Protestants and Catholics cracked down on the “free-thinking” that undermined their religious orthodoxies. But in the longer term, there was to be no turning back from the development of scientific and philosophical inquiry, the dissemination of knowledge and culture in printed books, and innovation in the arts.

AFTER

Renaissance thinkers came in conflict with the Church, but their achievements lived on.

RELIGIOUS REACTION

In 1542 the Catholic Church established the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith in Rome as a body to **suppress ideas contrary to the Church's teaching**. In 1564 Pope Pius IV established an **Index of Proscribed [banned] Books**, which included the works of Erasmus and Copernicus. Giordano Bruno, a wide-ranging thinker in the Renaissance tradition, was **burned at the stake** in Rome after the Congregation found him guilty of heresy in 1600.

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Through the 16th century, European painting, sculpture, and architecture developed in a less naturalistic direction, **valuing expression above harmony and true proportion**. This more artificial style has been labeled “Mannerism” by art historians. Mannerism evolved into the exuberant Baroque style dominant in the 17th century.

GALILEO

Working in Italian cities including Pisa, Padua, and Florence, Galileo Galilei (1564–1642) built on the **Renaissance spirit of inquiry and observation** to lay the foundations of the Scientific Revolution **266–67** >>

LATE RENAISSANCE

In some countries the Renaissance is generally agreed to have flowered at a later date. In both England and Spain, the height of the Renaissance did not occur until the second half of the 16th century and early 17th century, when writers, musicians and artists such as Thomas Tallis, Edmund Spenser, William Shakespeare, El Greco, and Miguel Cervantes all flourished.